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Spatiality, Fugitivity, and "Black Livingness" in Harriet Jacobs's *Incidents in the Life of a Slave Girl*

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ABSTRACT
When Harriet Jacobs situates herself within her family history in *Incidents* (1861), she narrates her genealogy by referencing her family's relationship to spatiality. In so doing, I argue, she underscores not only the vast geographical reach and inherent injustice of slavery but also the strategic capabilities of the enslaved to negotiate with their owners, when possible, to strengthen their own agency and thus practice "black livingness" (Katherine McKittrick's coinage). Moreover, Jacobs frames her self-confinement in the garret attached to her grandmother Molly's house as domestic fugitivity (Tina Campt's term) facilitated by a sustained family effort. To support this reading, I demonstrate how systematically even the *pre*-fugitivity chapters narrate the crucial importance of Molly's household, a (bell) hooksian "homeplace", to young Jacobs. Finally, rather than calling Jacobs's domestic fugitivity "marronage", I seek to honour the historical specificity of marronage while acknowledging the subtle ways in which *Incidents* signals solidarity with southern maroons.

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"Much of what power is and how it is experienced is bound up with how it is *spatialized*", David Delaney argues in his analysis of American geographies of slavery and Jim Crow.[1] Elizabeth Bohls similarly remarks that "[t]he politics of slavery [...] played out to a significant degree as a politics of place",[2] and Stephanie Camp specifies that "places, boundaries, and movement were central to how slavery was organized and to how it was resisted" in the US antebellum South.[3] Viewed from this spatialised perspective, enslaved people's fugitivity meant breaking away from bondage by transcending, and refusing to acknowledge, the borders and boundaries established by the era's racialised legal landscapes and geographies of power.[4] This vantage point on antislavery resistance brings

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[1]Delaney, *Race, Place, and the Law,* 6; italics in original. Adam Bledsoe, LaToya Eaves, and Brian Williams identify Delaney's book as one of the critically important pre-2000 works that paved the way for the current flourishing of Black Geographies as an academic field ("Introduction," 8).

[2]Bohls, *Slavery and the Politics of Place*, 8. Even though Bohls focuses on the Caribbean, her argument applies to slavery in the American South as well.

[3]Camp, *Closer to Freedom*, 6.

[4]Delaney defines "geographies of power" as "those spatial configurations that reflect and reinforce social relations of power" and "legal landscapes" as "geographies of power described in terms of legal discourse" (*Race, Place, and the Law*, 5, 24).

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together human geography, spatiality,[5] and Black agency—or "black livingness", as Black Geographies scholar Katherine McKittrick calls processes of "seeking liberation, and reinventing the terms of black life outside normatively negative conceptions of blackness".[6] This spatial-cum-geographical approach also directly engages with Black corporeality and Black mobility because fugitivity was a physical act of movement whereby a Black body crossed a line, literally and figuratively, to resist enslavement and seek freedom.

Taking its cue from these intersections, this article examines representations of space and place in *Incidents in the Life of a Slave Girl* (1861),[7] the now-canonical memoir of Harriet Jacobs. The southern phase of Jacobs's fugitivity mostly consisted of the almost seven years that she spent concealed in the tiny garret of the storeroom that was attached to the house of her free maternal grandmother, Molly Horniblow ([Aunt] "Martha"/"Marthy" in *Incidents*),[8] in Edenton, North Carolina. Given this extraordinary spatial ordeal, multiple scholars have commented on Jacobs's renderings of spatiality in *Incidents*, as one would expect.[9] McKittrick's statement that Jacobs's "spatial experiences and strategies illustrate how the geographic workings of slavery simultaneously produce spatial boundaries and subject-knowledges that can subvert the perimeters of bondage" continues to be fundamental.[10] Inspired by McKittrick's theorisation, I argue that placing her concept of "black livingness" in dialogue with a historically informed close reading of Jacobs's spatial discourse in *Incidents* reveals how firmly Jacobs highlights individual and familial Black agency both in her stories of "everyday resistance" (in the quotidian yet vital sense proposed by Camp)[11] and in her

[5]The term "spatiality", as defined by Sheila Hones, "refers to socially produced space as opposed to Newtonian (absolute) container space" and "involves the idea that the social and the spatial are mutually productive and inseparable" (*Literary Geography*, 168). Henri Lefebvre's *The Production of Space* famously served as a major catalyst for relational theories of space, including Doreen Massey's articulation of space "as the product of interrelations" and "as constituted through interactions" (*For Space*, 9). Adopting neither the "container" view nor any theory that completely ignores the physical and material realities of what Delaney calls "the differing experiential geographies of real people" (*Race, Place, and the Law*, vii), I think of spaces and places as being both physical and socially—including juridically—constructed.

[6]McKittrick, *Dear Science*, 3. I capitalise "Black" and "Blackness" in my own prose. However, when I quote from texts that opt for the lowercase "b", such as *Dear Science*, I maintain the original language, which is why I lowercase the "b" in McKittrick's concept of "black livingness" throughout this article.

[7]Harriet Jacobs, *Incidents*. All subsequent references to *Incidents* will be to the second Norton edition (2019) and will be cited parenthetically in the text. Whenever I mention dates that are not included in *Incidents*, my source is, unless otherwise specified, the "Chronology" in Yellin et al., *The Harriet Jacobs Family Papers*, vol. 1, xlvix–lxiii.

[8]Due to my heavy reliance on the work of literary historians, I use the historical names of all individuals mentioned in *Incidents*. I give their pseudonyms, which Jacobs created to protect Black identities, in parentheses upon first mention. Of course, autobiography is not the same thing as historiography; life writing is constructed and mediated, and it includes selection, polishing, embellishment, and fictionalization (see, for example, Smith and Watson, *A Guide for Interpreting Life Narratives*). Nevertheless, I would find the distinction between, for example, "Harriet Jacobs, the author", and "Linda Brent, the narrator-protagonist", or between "Molly Horniblow, Harriet Jacobs's grandmother", and "[Aunt] Marthy/Martha, Linda Brent's grandmother", difficult to sustain systematically in this article. In referring to the historical individuals by their real names, I both follow the example set by Jean Fagan Yellin in *Harriet Jacobs: A Life* (in which she evokes *Incidents* frequently) and choose the option that I consider practical in the context of this article.

[9]Valerie Smith's 1990 essay "Loopholes of Retreat" was a foundational overview of Jacobs's treatment of spatiality in *Incidents*. While I cannot here converse with all literary-critical analyses of *Incidents* that address spatiality, I will dialogue with Gerrity, *Beyond Emancipation*; Gerrity, "Harriet Jacobs"; Kanzler, "To Tell the Kitchen Version"; and Randle, "Between the Rock and the Hard Place."

[10]McKittrick, *Demonic Grounds*, 40.

[11]See Camp, *Closer to Freedom,* especially 1–4. "Neither accommodationist nor a direct attack on slavery", writes Camp, referencing political scientist James Scott, "everyday resistance occupied […] the wide terrain between consent, on the one hand, and open, organized opposition, on the other" (2). Camp emphasises that the study of everyday resistance is vital to understanding the life experiences of enslaved women (3).

narrative of how her adult family members engage in extremely risky, high-stakes resistance by illegally harbouring her as a fugitive.

More specifically, the first part of this article posits that when, in the often quickly-skimmed first pages of *Incidents*, Jacobs situates herself within her Black family history—one marked not only by enslavement but also by cunning resistance to it—she often narrates her genealogy by referencing her family's relationship to geography and space. In so doing, she underscores not only the vast geographical reach and inherent injustice of slavery but also the strategic capabilities of the enslaved to negotiate with their owners, when possible, to strengthen their own agency and thus practice "black livingness", as I will demonstrate. Jacobs's spatially oriented narrative of her family members' agency resonates with historical scholarship (by, for example, Ira Berlin and Stephanie Camp) that highlights the multiplicity and heterogeneity of both southern slavery and Black resistance to it. Her depictions of clever covert and semi-overt everyday resistance in the antebellum South also indirectly point to the significance of Black abolitionism—a culmination of the era's direct and visible Black political agency—in the North, where Jacobs witnessed Black abolitionist activism, including the work of Frederick Douglass and her own younger brother, John Jacobs,[12] before she started writing her memoir.[13]

The second part of this article focuses on Molly's household as a (bell) hooksian "homeplace". I contend that reading *Incidents* from the perspective of domestic spatiality reveals a carefully crafted continuum between Jacobs's pre-garret and garret narratives, a continuum based on the vital importance of Molly's household to Jacobs during her *entire* life until her escape north. This narrative arc, which has not been reconstructed in full detail in literary analyses of *Incidents*, is extremely significant: it highlights *collective* familial Black agency and resistance, especially the family's multigenerational Black female agency and resistance, as the existential core of the North Carolina segment of *Incidents*, rather than Jacobs casting herself as an individual heroic slave detached from any Black support system.

The final part of this article is a conceptual analysis that segues from my characterisation of Jacobs's ordeal in the garret as "domestic fugitivity" (a term I borrow from Tina Campt's theorisation of the emergence of Black German subjectivity) into a broader terminological comparison of "fugitivity" and "marronage". My terminological discussion is prompted by the current scholarly interest in marronage—a topic that is, indeed, vitally important in the study of Black geography and spatiality.[14] Sean Gerrity has recently interpreted Jacobs's fugitivity in the garret as marronage,[15] participating in the presently popular trend of expanding the meaning of marronage beyond its traditional definition.

[12]In this article, the variants John Jacobs (which I use for brevity), John S. Jacobs (traditionally used to identify the author of *A True Tale of Slavery* [1861]), and John Swanson Jacobs (used on the title page of the 2024 edition of *Despots* [1855]) all refer to the same historical figure, Harriet Jacobs's younger brother. See notes 13, 74, and 76 below.

[13]After fleeing to the North, Jacobs was exposed to northern abolitionism in multiple ways—especially in Rochester, New York, where she followed her brother, John, living there from March 1849 to September 1850. There, and previously in Boston, she witnessed closely John's Garrisonian activism. After Douglass's and John's shared antislavery speaking tour in early 1849, she helped John run an Anti-Slavery Office and Reading Room in the same building that housed the office of Douglass's *North Star* in downtown Rochester. She initially stayed in the home of the prominent Quaker abolitionists Isaac and Amy Post and absorbed the mentality of the movement through conversations with her hosts and with the activists who frequented the Post residence. See Yellin, *Harriet Jacobs: A Life*, 101–7.

[14]For a brief overview of relevant scholarly studies of marronage, see Gerrity, *Beyond Emancipation*, 4, 161–62n6.

[15]Gerrity, *Beyond Emancipation*; Gerrity, "Harriet Jacobs."

Hesitant to embrace this trend, I instead evoke Gabrielle Foreman's concept of "simultextuality" to discuss the ways in which Jacobs addresses *both* fugitivity and marronage in her memoir. Rather than using "marronage" metaphorically, I seek to honour the historical specificity of southern marronage as well as acknowledge the subtle ways in which *Incidents* signals solidarity with southern maroons.

Geographies of Power and "Black Livingness"

Addressing what was, from Jacobs's vantage point, the almost omnipresent geographical reach of slavery within the United States, the opening paragraph of *Incidents* not only introduces Molly but also offers an intergenerationally passed remembrance that illuminates the fragility of Black freedom across American time–space:

> She [Molly] was the daughter of a planter in South Carolina, who, at his death, left her mother and his three children free, with money to go to St. Augustine, where they had relatives. It was during the Revolutionary War; and they were captured on their passage, carried back, and sold to different purchasers. (9)

These two sentences relate a tragic wartime story about a manumitted—that is, legally free—Black family trying to relocate within the Deep South during the American Revolution.[16] Never reaching their destination, they were illegally captured, sold, and separated from each other. Given that Jacobs's own (not legally recognised) self-emancipation had been in constant peril during her 1835–52 fugitivity and that her decision to write *Incidents* was largely prompted by the 1850 Fugitive Slave Act's aftermath[17] (which, among other things, compelled her fugitive brother, John, to leave the East Coast and eventually the United States),[18] it is only logical that she would place this account of precarious Black freedom, which could be taken away at any time, in the opening paragraph of her memoir, thereby granting it a prominent position in the text.

However, while the far- and deep-reaching terror of slavery permeates *Incidents*, so does Jacobs's counter-emphasis on the capacity of Black agency to survive and thrive against the odds—that is, her focus on Black capability to embrace and practice what McKittrick calls "black livingness". As Ira Berlin stresses—challenging the most rigid "social death" interpretations of the Peculiar Institution—"slavery, though imposed and maintained by violence, was a negotiated relationship" because even though "the playing field was never level, the master-slave relationship was nevertheless subject to continual negotiation".[19] I do not wish to overemphasise this point or suggest its universal applicability to every enslaver-enslaved relationship. Nevertheless, I argue that in *Incidents* Jacobs depicts multiple processes of "continual negotiation" in the intimately

[16]St. Augustine, Florida, was behind British lines during the American Revolution.

[17]Jacobs escaped from her enslaver in 1835. She fled to the North in 1842, the same year that the US Supreme Court decided in favour of the slave catcher Edward Prigg in *Prigg v. Pennsylvania* and thus "upheld", as Manisha Sinha writes, "the constitutionality of the Fugitive Slave Act of 1793 and declared all northern state laws that contravened it unconstitutional" (*The Slave's Cause*, 390). Intensified by the passage of the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850, the threat and fear of recapture shadowed, and at times completely dominated, Jacobs's life until 1852, when her employer purchased her freedom and thereby legally terminated her fugitive status (see Yellin, *Harriet Jacobs: A Life*, 108–16). Soon afterward, in a letter to Amy Post (Yellin et al., *The Harriet Jacobs Family Papers*, vol. 1, 190–1), Jacobs expressed her willingness to do what was "best for the welfare of the [antislavery] cause" by writing her memoir and having it published (ibid., 191).

[18]Schroeder, *No Longer Yours*, 150–79. See also note 76 below.

[19]Berlin, *Many Thousands Gone*, 2.

intertwined languages of geography, spatiality, and mobility/fixity to highlight, against the odds, "black livingness": not only does she illuminate the centrality of the dialectic of slave containment versus slave mobility in conflicts between owners and owned, but she also brings into relief enslaved persons' capabilities to live out and expand their agency even under confined circumstances of limited movement. In particular, Jacobs recounts how purposefully her enslaved father, Elijah Knox,[20] expanded his mobility and how determinedly Molly, before and after gaining her freedom, gradually improved her conditions under her spatially more fixed circumstances.

Indeed, despite Jacobs's focus on the wide and deep reach of slavery, "black livingness", too, is present in the very opening of *Incidents*, embedded in a depiction of how an enslaved man's negotiated mobility allowed him to distance himself, physically and psychologically, from some of the most diminishing aspects of the logic of slavery. That is, Jacobs's first mention of her father foregrounds his professional skills, which enabled him to work at locations beyond his primary site of bondage: "My father was a carpenter, and considered so intelligent and skilful in his trade, that, when buildings out of the common line were to be erected, he was sent for from long distances, to be head workman" (9). Jacobs connects Elijah's ability to be physically away from his owner's property, when hired out to perform skilled labour, to self-empowerment and a certain amount of independence: "On condition of paying his mistress two hundred dollars a year, and supporting himself, he was allowed to work at his trade, and manage his own affairs" (9). Jacobs places this spatial-cum-financial arrangement within the framework of Black freedom-seeking by linking it directly to Elijah's repeated, and repeatedly denied, requests to be allowed to purchase his children's freedom (9). In other words, Jacobs here both powerfully critiques slavery's ideological refusal to acknowledge the significance of Black family ties (one of the most prevalent themes in the memoir) *and*, at the same time, spotlights Elijah's project of expanding his physical and psychosocial freedom, which meant, first, making as good a financial use of his work-related mobility as possible under the conditions of his enslavement, and, second, providing his wife, Delilah Horniblow, and their children with a "comfortable" (9) domestic space (which, it is reasonable to assume, he himself kept in good condition by taking care of repairs). There their daughter, Harriet, was happy for the first six years of her life, "so fondly shielded that I never dreamed I was a piece of merchandise" (9).

While this brief spotlight on Elijah's strategic capabilities is noteworthy, in the early chapters of *Incidents* it is Molly who functions as the primary embodiment of McKittrick's "black livingness". After the tragically interrupted journey to St. Augustine, young Molly was purchased by an Englishman named John Horniblow, who took her to his plantation in Edenton, North Carolina. "In 1797", Jonathan Schroeder tells us, "Horniblow bought Robert Egan's tavern and moved to town", and the tavern came to be known as Horniblow's Tavern.[21] In the years that followed, Molly's life seems to have been largely focused on a single site, the tavern and its affairs. Her existence as an enslaved woman therefore exemplifies what Camp, stressing that enslaved women "as a group [...] enjoyed much less mobility than did men", calls a gendered "geography

[20]Jacobs refers to her parents as "father" and "mother", without providing them with pseudonyms. For information about Elijah Knox and his family history, see Schroeder, *No Longer Yours*, 80–93.
[21]Schroeder, *No Longer Yours*, 91.

of containment".[22] However, despite this spatial fixity, "containment" does not convey the whole truth about the extent of Molly's agency. In Jacobs's treatment, domestic rhetoric, when applied to Molly, does not merely function as a rhetoric of submission; rather, Jacobs emphasises that Molly, like Elijah, knew how to negotiate while enslaved. The narrative of Molly's activities at the tavern includes, but also far transcends, what Anne Bradford Warner calls Jacobs's representation of Molly as "the very essence of the domestic craft":[23] not only does Jacobs explain that Molly "became an indispensable personage in the household, officiating in all capacities, from cook and wet nurse to seamstress" (9–10), but she also underscores that Molly used her indispensability as leverage and "asked permission of her mistress to bake crackers at night, after all the household work was done; and she obtained leave to do it, provided she would clothe herself and her children from the profits" (10). As with her depiction of Elijah, Jacobs again spotlights Black skilled labour, agency, and freedom-seeking, making clear that Molly utilised the space available to her to advance her own cause: during her midnight baking sessions, she transformed a key site of her bondage, the tavern's kitchen, into a site of labour that profited her financially, and the goal of her project was similar to that of Elijah's—to purchase her children's freedom.

Jacobs's narrative of Molly's negotiating abilities is not limited to the tavern's kitchen. Even though Molly's hopes of freeing all or most of her children were soon dashed (10), *Incidents* reveals that she, stunningly, managed to win a major battle in one of the notoriously iconic spaces of the slave South: she was able to manipulate the auction block. This story is so often ignored in interpretive scholarship that a summary of it is warranted here:[24] Elizabeth Pritchard Horniblow, Molly's mistress[25] and the widow of John Horniblow, wanted Molly to be manumitted following her death. However, after Elizabeth died in 1827, Jacobs's nemesis, James A. Norcom ("Dr. Flint"), informed Molly that she was going to be sold, after all, due to financial exigencies (14). Norcom wanted to sell her quickly and privately, but Jacobs's depiction of how Molly insisted on making the process public highlights, again, Molly's agency and determination: "[I]f he was base enough to sell her, when her mistress intended she should be free, she was determined the public should know it" (14). Before the auction date, Molly struck a deal with her late mistress's sister, Hannah Pritchard, who, according to Jacobs, "had lived forty years under the same roof with my grandmother" (14). The two women were convinced that, due to Molly's central role at the tavern and her excellent reputation in the community, the local whites would hesitate or even refuse to bid for her, enabling Pritchard to purchase Molly—with the money that Molly had painstakingly earned with her midnight baking—and emancipate her afterward. The scheme worked: on the auction day of 1 January 1828, Molly "took her place among the chattels, and at the first call she sprang upon the auction-block", but the crowd shouted that the auction block was "no

[22]Camp, *Closer to Freedom*, 6.
[23]Warner, "Harriet Jacobs at Home," 36.
[24]My summary draws on *Incidents*, 14–15; and Yellin, *Harriet Jacobs: A Life*, 21–2. See also "Chronology", in Yellin et al., *The Harriet Jacobs Family Papers*, vol. 1, lii; "Horniblow, Molly (ca. 1771–1853)" in "Brief Biographies" in ibid., lxx; "Sale of Land and Slaves of Elizabeth Horniblow, January 1 and February 1, 1828" in ibid., 19–21; documents related to Molly Horniblow's emancipation in ibid., 22–5; "Deed to Molly Horniblow, June 23, 1830" in ibid., 25–7; and "Molly Horniblow's Petition to Emancipate Marcus Ramsey, November 30, 1842" in ibid., 45–51.
[25]In my own prose, I use the term "mistress" to refer to a white slave-owning woman. For a longer discussion of this usage and its justifications, see Jones-Rogers, *They Were Her Property*, xv–xvi.

place" for her (14). Pritchard made the only bid for her. After the legalities were settled with the help of the attorney and congressman Alfred Moore Gatlin, Molly gained her freedom (15). As part of the same process, Molly was able to purchase one of her children, the Jacobs siblings' uncle Marcus (Mark) Ramsey ([Uncle] "Phillip"/"Phil"). Also, Gatlin sold his empty house to Molly for a nominal price in 1830, and she opened a bakery there and started her life as a free woman. As a result of her "perseverance and unwearied industry", Molly "was now mistress of a snug little home", as Jacobs puts it, "surrounded with the necessaries of life" (18). The once enslaved Molly was now a free female entrepreneur with her own space—her own house, no less, a visible emblem of "black livingness".

"Homeplace" as a Black Safe Space

In her essay "Homeplace", bell hooks (Gloria Jean Watkins) argues that, "Historically, [...] Black women resisted by making homes where all black people could strive to be subjects, not objects".[26] In *Incidents*, Molly's household—Jacobs's anchor in Edenton—epitomises a hooksian "homeplace" that is created by a Black woman as a safe "space[] of care and nurturance in the face of the brutal harsh reality of racist oppression, of sexist domination".[27] The importance of Jacobs's "homeplace" narrative, which deliberately contradicts the era's racist assumption that the only meaningful forms of southern family life and domesticity were white, cannot be overemphasised, and Molly's role in this narrative is crucial. According to Jean Fagan Yellin, the childhood home that Jacobs evokes in *Incidents*—the home of Elijah, Delilah, and their children—was "one of the outbuildings behind Horniblow's Tavern".[28] This means that Molly was a strong, protective presence in the lives of Harriet and her brother, John ("William"/"Willie"), from the outset. Following Delilah's death in 1819, the six-year-old Harriet, according to *Incidents*, moved to the residence of Margaret Horniblow, Elizabeth Horniblow's unmarried and chronically ill daughter, who had been Delilah's mistress (10–11). However, Yellin indicates that Harriet did not, in fact, move far but continued to stay on the tavern property, because Margaret Horniblow lived there—with her mother Elizabeth, Molly's mistress—almost until her passing.[29] While the change in young Harriet's spatial and sociocultural circumstances was significant enough to make her realise, for the first time, that she was enslaved (10), Jacobs offers relatively carefree memories of this phase in her life, not only of serving as her benevolent mistress's companion and helper indoors but also of being permitted to enjoy the outdoors with the happy mobility and physicality of a child:

> I would sit by her [Margaret Horniblow's] side for hours, sewing diligently, with a heart as free from care as that of any free-born white child. When she thought I was tired, she would send me out to run and jump; and away I bounded, to gather berries or flowers to decorate her room. (11)

Most importantly, Harriet's relatively privileged status as Margaret Horniblow's protected slave never seems to have weakened her connection with Molly or the rest of

[26]hooks, "Homeplace," 42.
[27]Ibid.
[28]Yellin, *Harriet Jacobs: A Life*, 8.
[29]Ibid., 11–14.

her extended family, and Yellin emphasises that their presence in Harriet's life continued to be steady and nurturing.[30]

After Margaret Horniblow's death in 1825, Harriet was sent back to Molly's care, but only temporarily (11). Bequeathed by Horniblow to her three-year-old niece, James A. Norcom's daughter Mary Matilda, Harriet was soon forced to move to the house, also located in downtown Edenton,[31] of the licentious and manipulative Norcom and his second wife. *Incidents* depicts this consequential life change in language that centres on the notion of home: "When we [Harriet and John] entered our new home we encountered cold looks, cold words, and cold treatment" (12). In Jacobs's depiction of Margaret Horniblow, the motif of flowers and flower arrangements highlighted young Harriet's close relationship with her "kind mistress" (11; see above). By contrast, in the narrative of the immediate aftermath of Elijah's death in 1826, the flower motif reveals the callous indifference of Mrs. Norcom, the memoir's cruel mistress incarnate, to the anguish of the newly orphaned adolescent:

> I thought I should be allowed to go to my father's house the next morning; but I was ordered to go for flowers, that my mistress's house might be decorated for an evening party. I spent the day gathering flowers and weaving them into festoons, while the dead body of my father was lying within a mile of me. (13)

Here, "distance" no longer signifies Elijah's mobility but, instead, Harriet and John's containment as they are shown their place, figuratively and literally, in the Norcom household. Elijah had once scolded young John for obeying his mistress rather than him ("You are *my* child", 12; italics in original); however, the supremacy of master and mistress is made clear to Elijah's children even before his passing and is given renewed emphasis after his death. As part of their project of controlling Black mobility and familial belonging, the Norcoms, significantly, declare Molly's hospitable home to be forbidden territory for Harriet, even though they themselves do not provide the growing adolescent with such necessities as sufficient food (13). Under these challenging circumstances, the brief, stolen moments with Molly—who finds a way to work around the spatial ban—become Harriet's lifeline: "[M]y grandmother, to avoid detaining me, often stood at the gate with something for my breakfast or dinner. I was indebted to *her* for all my comforts, spiritual or temporal" (13; italics in original).

Indeed, Jacobs consistently portrays Molly's household, be it her home on the tavern property or her own freedwoman's house, as an emblem not only of exemplary housekeeping but also of both an entrepreneurial spirit and familial generosity: "There was a grand big oven there, too, that baked bread and nice things for the town, and we [Harriet and John] knew there was always a choice bit in store for us" (19). By contrast, in discussing the kitchen in the Norcom house, Jacobs casts Mrs. Norcom as a hypocritical member of the slaveholding class who, though exempt from supervising kitchen operations due to her allegedly delicate disposition, finds the energy to come up with remarkably creative punishments if she is unhappy with the work of her cook—especially

[30]Ibid., 11.

[31]See ibid., 17; see also the illustration entitled "Map of Edenton, North Carolina, 1813–1842" in the same volume (n.p., between "Afterword" and "Notes"). Despite Gerrity's claim that Jacobs "grew up enslaved on Dr. Norcom's plantation" (*Beyond Emancipation*, 105; "Harriet Jacobs," 73), Jacobs actually grew up as an enslaved town-dweller. See *Incidents*, 28–29, 33.

if Sunday dinner, following church, is served even a little late (15); Jacobs here participates in Douglass's famously fierce condemnation of "the *slaveholding religion* of this land".[32] The memoir's true paragon of female virtue is all along Molly, whom Jacobs calls her/the "good grandmother" as many as six times in the text (10, 13, 39, 52, 99, 131). Unlike the morally and spiritually corrupted mistress Norcom, Molly embodies "*true* womanhood",[33] as Hazel Carby argued as early as 1987—a remark that signifies on the familiar notion of the nineteenth-century white, middle- and upper-class American "cult of true womanhood"[34] and provides a repetition with difference, given Molly's status as an initially enslaved and then manumitted Black woman. One major aspect of this difference is that in *Incidents* Molly, unlike the white women privileged in the era's domestic ideologies, engages in profitable work that financially both supports her and assists her family members—with her kitchen being elevated to a symbol of honest labour, perseverance, and Black familial love and caring. Jacobs's kitchen narratives featuring Molly are, I repeat, extremely important:[35] they highlight her central role in *Incidents* and illustrate the ways in which antebellum Black women engaged in "everyday forms of resistance",[36] in the sense analysed by Camp, as they lived out their agency in southern spaces.

Some scholars, including Gloria T. Randle—whose interest in "mediating spaces" in *Incidents* prompts her to discuss Molly rather extensively—have assessed Jacobs's representation of her grandmother more negatively.[37] Randle's psychoanalytically oriented reading of Molly focuses on what she regards as Molly's "imposing and uncompromising righteousness", her "severe lapses in judgment", and her "covetous kind of mothering".[38] As for Molly's "covetous" grandmothering, it is true that she initially tries to persuade Jacobs to drop her escape plan (80); however, it is crucial to note that *Incidents* represents Molly's desire to keep her family close as a natural human need that, in her case, stems from both love and trauma. After all, the numerous and profound losses and difficulties that Molly has experienced include, for example, an unrelenting uncertainty about what happened to her son Joseph Horniblow ("Benjamin"), whose second escape from slavery resulted in his complete disappearance from the family's life (26). As for Randle's reference to Molly's "righteousness", *Incidents* does include a scene in which Molly's standard of unconditional familial love clashes dramatically with her early-nineteenth-century understanding of the Christian code of sexual morality (51–2): during Jacobs's first pregnancy, James Norcom's wife visits Molly and falsely accuses Jacobs, who is present during the confrontation, of having seduced her husband (who, despite his lecherous disposition, is not the baby's father). Molly receives more new information and misinformation than she can process in one sitting, and during her initial shock she disowns Jacobs and tells her never to set a foot in her house again. However, the crux of the matter is that this

[32]Douglass, *Narrative*, 79; italics in original.
[33]Carby, *Reconstructing Womanhood,* 57; italics in original.
[34]Barbara Welter famously coined this term in "The Cult of True Womanhood: 1820–1860."
[35]Katja Kanzler's "To Tell the Kitchen Version", which focuses on the kitchen motif in *Incidents* and Harriet Wilson's *Our Nig*, discusses the kitchens in the Norcom house and in the household of Martha Hoskins Rombough Blount (for verification of the latter's name, see Yellin, *Harriet Jacobs: A Life*, 45), but makes no mention of either the enslaved Molly in the tavern's kitchen or the emancipated Molly in the kitchen of her own house.
[36]Camp, *Closer to Freedom*, 10.
[37]Randle, "Between the Rock and the Hard Place," 45–7.
[38]Ibid., 45.

brief, temporary falling out between grandmother and granddaughter is soon followed by explanations and reconciliation, and Jacobs is again welcomed into Molly's house, the hooksian "homeplace" that offers familial care and nurturing. Randle's Freudian-inspired critique of Molly's allegedly flawed grandmothering overlooks how proudly Jacobs places herself within her family history of Black agency and "livingness"—and, as explained above, Jacobs's narrated genealogy of agency and resistance emphasises not only Elijah's "feelings of a freeman" (12) but also Molly's remarkable, determinedly created path to her eventual existence as a free Black woman who resides and works in her own house while living within a slave society. Indeed, although Molly and her granddaughter have their intergenerational disagreements, it is Molly's home—a physical space and a socially produced space, a welcoming Black household—to which Jacobs returns *repeatedly* in search of refuge, shelter, and sustenance, both as a girl and as a young woman.

Even Jacobs's initial commentary on how she found some refuge in small-town living when being sexually preyed upon circles back to Molly's status as her primary protector. At this stage of the memoir's chronology, Norcom's predatory sexual advances have already begun, but the teenage Jacobs has not yet found the courage to confide in Molly about his behaviour:

> [H]er [Molly's] presence in the neighborhood was some protection to me. Though she had been a slave, Dr. Flint [Norcom] was afraid of her. He dreaded her scorching rebukes. Moreover, she was known and patronized by many people; and he did not wish to have his villainy made public. It was lucky for me that I did not live on a distant plantation, but in a town not so large that the inhabitants were ignorant of each other's affairs. [...] [T]he doctor, as a professional man, deemed it prudent to keep up some outward show of decency. (28–9)

This passage invites three comments. First, from the perspective of spatiality and human geography, it is noteworthy that Jacobs's remarks echo, albeit with a difference, Douglass's famous depiction of how the presence of white neighbours in urban environments made slaveowners slower to resort to physical brutality than was the case in the countryside.[39] Jacobs, however, repeatedly makes a more deliberate distinction than does Douglass between a "town" where people knew each other and the potential anonymity of "city" life:

> How often did I rejoice that I lived in a town where all the inhabitants knew each other! If I had been on a remote plantation, or lost among the multitude of a crowded city, I should not be a living woman at this day. (33)

Second, while some readers may question whether the historical Norcom was as concerned about Molly's "scorching rebukes" as *Incidents* suggests, Jacobs's point about the physician desiring to guard his reputation among white Edentonians, including his family, is fully believable: "The old sinner was politic. The application of the lash [onto Jacobs's body] might have led to remarks that would have exposed him in the eyes of his children and grandchildren" (33). Third, given Molly's near-ubiquitous presence in the Edenton chapters, the North Carolina segment of *Incidents* reads like a family memoir: Jacobs continuously evokes family members and relatives in her narrative, and the storylines featuring Molly and her house stand out in their importance and centrality.

[39]Douglass, *Narrative*, 31–2.

The vital significance of Molly's home as Jacobs's safe place permeates the narrative that covers the timeline between Jacobs's pregnancy with her first child—fathered by Samuel Tredwell Sawyer ("Mr. Sands"), a local attorney and politician with whom Jacobs forms a liaison to deter Norcom's advances—and the beginning of her ordeal in the garret. When the teenage Jacobs falls pregnant, she, despite her grandmother's initial shock, ends up moving from the Norcom household back to Molly's; Jacobs is still owned by the Norcoms, but the fiercely jealous Mrs. Norcom no longer wants her under her roof (53). Notably, this arrangement lasts for years: Jacobs is still living with Molly when she gives birth to her and Sawyer's son, Joseph ("Benjamin"/"Benny"), in 1829 (55); experiences a post-Nat Turner raid in 1831 (56–60); and delivers her and Sawyer's daughter, Louisa Matilda ("Ellen"), in 1833 (67–8). It is from Molly's house that she eventually relocates to Auburn (the plantation of Norcom's son, James Norcom Jr., located about six miles from Edenton) when Norcom revives his old plan of isolating Jacobs to a remote cottage to keep her there as his sex slave (73)—the same plan that, years earlier, had served as the final factor pushing her to seek protection from Sawyer (50).[40] This time, Jacobs opts for the alternative that Norcom now offers: work at Auburn. However, she tries to keep Joseph and Louisa at Molly's house to prevent them from being turned into plantation slaves, and she secretly visits them there while trying to formulate an escape plan (78). When she learns that they are about to be brought to Auburn to be "broke in" (82), she flees, in order to turn the Norcoms' attention away from her children, and thus officially becomes a fugitive in the eyes of the law. The first place she goes during the night of her escape is, again, Molly's house (83–4), although she then temporarily moves on to avoid immediate capture. In sum, the pre-fugitivity chapters of *Incidents* demonstrate systematically, from one stage of Jacobs's life in North Carolina to another, that when she eventually re-enters Molly's house to hide in the horrifyingly small garret, she returns to the household that has always been her anchor.

Tina Campt's term "domestic fugitivity",[41] which she coined when examining vernacular family photographs of Black Germans, can be adopted and adapted to characterise Jacobs's years in the garret: Jacobs's domestic fugitivity signifies familial refuge, in harmony with Campt's primary usage of the term.[42] However, given that Campt analyses material from the Nazi era, in her usage the "fugitivity" in "domestic fugitivity" does not reference a Black subject's legal status as a runaway in the US antebellum South but instead focuses, more metaphorically, on the relief that familial embrace may provide by offering an escape from the surrounding society's racialising and politically marginalising pressures; this is also the meaning of Campt's synonymous "fugitive domesticity".[43] Unlike Campt, I use the terms "fugitive" and "fugitivity" specifically in relation to slave law, and I refer to Jacobs as a "domestic fugitive" once her status, in

[40]As Mary Jo Bona writes, "Recognizing the ruinous desire involved in Dr. Flint's having built a 'cottage' for her, Linda does not need expertise in domestic architecture to know its fundamentally antidomestic meaning: sexual enslavement" (*Mothers, Mobility*, 36).

[41]Campt, *Image Matters*, 108, 111.

[42]Campt employs such phrases as "domestic fugitivity and embrace" when discussing a racialised and marginalised Black German subject's site of "belonging and identification" (ibid., 108). For Campt, such a site can be either one's family or a supportive communal context "supplement[ing] the familial context" (ibid.).

[43]Campt, *Image Matters*, 100. For a longer analysis of Campt's theorization of fugitivity in *Image Matters* and beyond, see von Gleich, *Black Border*, 40–3.

Incidents, has become that of a runaway who is hiding in Molly's garret. When Jacobs begins her domestic fugitivity in this sense, as distinct from having resided at Molly's previously, she is an outlaw and must therefore live concealed in the *margin* of the "homeplace", rather being able to participate in her family's daily life. In the pre-garret chapters of *Incidents*, domesticity in the hooksian homeplace signified not only Molly's domicile as a physical space but also the familial embrace and Black affirmation and nurturing that was, for Jacobs, the vital social product emanating from that space. In the garret narrative, Jacobs's family continues to support her, but her new status as a fugitive, a breaker of the slave law, turns this domestic support into extremely risky, high-stakes political resistance. Nowhere in *Incidents* is Jacobs's dual emphasis on *both* the vital importance *and* the precarity of what hooks calls the project "of making a homeplace, of making home a community of resistance"[44] so heightened as it is in the narrative of her years in the garret.

For almost seven years, Jacobs's adult family members risk everything by harbouring her as a runaway. After her escape from Auburn, they, in fact, initially counsel her to return to the Norcoms (85). However, they soon come to terms with her choice and decide to help her, despite the punishments they receive immediately for their suspected solidarity with Jacobs's defiance and despite the years-long risk-taking that follows. Molly is at the core of the family effort facilitating Jacobs's domestic fugitivity, but Jacobs also repeatedly mentions being assisted in various ways by her uncle Mark Ramsey (96–8, 104, 107–8, 117–18, 126, 128–9, 131)—and, when possible, by John (103–4), prior to his escape from his second master, Sawyer, in 1838. Aunt Betty Horniblow ("Aunt Nancy"), who is owned by the Norcoms and whom Jacobs identifies as Delilah's twin sister (121), also provides her niece with deeply valuable practical assistance and emotional support as long as her own precarious health enables her to do so (98, 120–1); she dies before Jacobs leaves the garret (121–4).[45] While the opportunity to secretly observe her children from her "loophole of retreat" is a precious lifeline for Jacobs, the adult members of her family help her to survive the ordeal *both* physically and psychologically. They persist in protecting her, although Norcom's punishments, in the form of physical confinement in jail, materialise for the family even before the fugitive Jacobs herself begins her self-confinement in the garret: once the vindictive Norcom realises that Jacobs has escaped from Auburn, he throws Betty and John—and Joseph and Louisa with them—into the Chowan County Jail (87), and Mark, too, is soon briefly arrested (94).[46]

Scholars have examined, in great detail, Jacobs's representation of the health- and life-threatening effects of her garret experience, including her exposure to heat and cold (as well as to vermin and rodents), her illnesses, her woefully inadequate opportunities to maintain her physical stamina and flexibility, her sensory and social deprivation, and her tragic inability to interact directly with her children. The narrative of her cunning resistance—especially her letter-writing from the garret, through which she manipulates

[44]hooks, "Homeplace," 42.

[45]As Schroeder notes, those who "kept the secret of Harriet's whereabouts" also included Betty's husband, Stephen Bozman, and another seafaring man, "known only as 'Peter'" (*No Longer Yours*, 106). For Jacobs's depiction of how Bozman and "Peter" took her to Cabarrus Pocosin to hide there temporarily, see *Incidents*, 95–7.

[46]Molly's son Joseph Horniblow had been incarcerated in the same prison earlier, following his first escape from slavery (*Incidents* 22–4). For a thorough analysis of Jacobs's prison narratives in *Incidents*, see Green, *Bound to Respect*, 27–65.

Norcom to pursue false leads when tracking her—has not escaped scholarly attention either. As Sean Gerrity writes, "Most critics agree that the garret is in some way a space of empowerment for Brent despite the nature of its physical and psychological confinement, while taking care to avoid idealizing or romanticizing it".[47] Indeed, on the one hand, the garret narrative subtly highlights Jacobs's innovative trickstering and guerrilla manoeuvring, thereby underscoring her extraordinary resilience and creative agency. On the other hand, *Incidents* makes very clear that the domestic fugitive Jacobs carries the heavy burden of knowing all along that the physically violent force of slavery could be unleashed on her and her family at any time. Even after Betty, John, Joseph, Louisa, and Mark are all released from prison, Jacobs remains acutely aware that her self-concealment in the garret might end in horrific punishment for everyone associated with her as well as the destruction of Molly's precious homeplace: "Had the least suspicion rested on my grandmother's house, it would have been burned to the ground" (100). During Jacobs's domestic fugitivity, Molly's house is a site of both courageous, covert resistance to enslavement and of continuing subalternity imposed on the family by the violent rule and logic of slavery.

Domestic Fugitivity or Marronage?

I have above privileged the conceptual framework of "fugitivity", due to the importance of the Fugitive Slave Law for Jacobs's project. Excluding her mentions of the "Fugitive Slave Law" itself, Jacobs uses the word "fugitive" fifteen times in *Incidents*, and she explicitly refers to herself both as a "fugitive" in the South and as a (pre-manumission) "fugitive" in the North (see, for example, 95, 141). In other words, she does not shy away from using the lexicon of fugitivity, and she applies it to herself as well as to others. However, Sean Gerrity has recently advocated for interpreting Jacobs's fugitivity in the garret as "marronage".[48] To briefly recapitulate the relevant background, Jacobs's perilous pre-garret fugitivity included not only her stay in her initial hiding place, of which little is known, and her concealment in the house of white Martha Hoskins Rombough Blount, which was facilitated by Molly's acquaintance with this benevolent wife of a slaveowner (86), but also her short, barely two-day stay in Cabarrus Pocosin ("Snaky Swamp"). Cabarrus Pocosin was a wetland southwest of Edenton that, as Yellin points out, "lay near the Great Dismal Swamp", which, in turn, was "for two centuries the largest hideout for fugitive slaves in North Carolina and Virginia".[49] In the southern imaginary, the Great Dismal Swamp was, indeed, closely associated with marronage. Sylviane A. Diouf notes in *Slavery's Exiles*, her landmark book on marronage in the American South, that "[t]he existence of hidden families, groups, and individuals in the [Great Dismal] swamp had been known about since the early 1700s", and she specifies that this swamp seems to have "held the largest number of maroons in the United States".[50] Tapping into this history, Gerrity not only categorises Jacobs's brief, hellish

[47]Gerrity, *Beyond Emancipation*, 113; Gerrity, "Harriet Jacobs," 80.
[48]Gerrity, *Beyond Emancipation*, 24, 97–120; Gerrity, "Harriet Jacobs."
[49]Yellin, *Harriet Jacobs: A Life*, 47.
[50]Diouf, *Slavery's Exiles*, 209, 210. For book-length histories of marronage in the Great Dismal Swamp (which is not Diouf's sole regional focus in *Slavery's Exiles*), see Nevius, *City of Refuge*; Sayers, *Desolate Place*.

visit to Cabarrus Pocosin as maroon activity but also conceptually reframes Jacobs's years in the garret as marronage. He articulates his rationale for this approach as follows:

> *Truant*—like *fugitive*, *outlaw*, or *runaway*—is a castigatory term, a definition by a negative that emerges from the law and lexicon of the slaveholder and reinscribes slavery's gaze of subjection even when we mean to denounce that gaze [...]. [M]arronage suggests alternative possibilities for and configurations of freedom, while fugitivity suggests a state of compromised being in relation to slave law.[51]

However, while I applaud the interpretive drive behind Gerrity's terminological choice—his desire to highlight Black agency rather than privilege slave law's legal fictions—I am not ready to discredit the impressive amount of scholarship utilising the established terms he identifies, including "fugitive", and to label all such scholarship as insensitive to the importance of foregrounding Black agency and subjectivity.

Admittedly, no single, authoritative definition of marronage exists. Given that Jacobs's concealment in the garret eschews any traditional, conceptually "tidy" category of marronage, the key question is how far one is willing to stretch the concept's traditional meaning/s (that is, its traditional meaning/s in the context of the US antebellum South, as distinct from other relevant settings, such as the Caribbean, Surinamese, or Brazilian ones). If, in the antebellum South, a free Black person secretly harboured a Black fugitive in their own house in a town located within a slave society—a town where they were a known entity to the whites and where they even operated a small business—did they and their close allies form a maroon community with the fugitive? If one answers "yes" to this question, then it makes sense to define Molly's household in Edenton as a maroon community during Jacobs's years in the garret. (Whether Jacobs's children should be conceptually included in this "maroon community" is a complicated question because they lived with Molly but were not told about their mother hiding in the garret.)[52] Or if one maintains that, in the pre-Civil War United States, any act of escaping from southern slavery was marronage—including any individual escape, possibly without any subsequent community formation, and with any environment as the destination—then fugitivity and marronage are in effect synonymous, which means that any Black antebellum fugitive fleeing from bondage, including Jacobs, can be classified as a maroon in today's interpretive scholarship, as long as the scholar's emphasis is on Black agency and subjectivity rather than on slave law. But is this blurring of conceptual boundaries useful? Gerrity keeps his interpretive discourse open-ended and fluid: "My definition of marronage is not so much a definition as it is a constellatory set of freedom-seeking practices by which unregistered frequencies of Black life and proactive agency coursed beneath the radar of a white supremacist state".[53] Yet, marronage was a historically specific, albeit internally diverse, phenomenon. Because I would like to retain at least some of the concept's historical uniqueness, I next delve deeper into some aspects of the current terminological discussion, with a particular interest in Diouf's conceptual criteria for marronage in the US antebellum South.

[51]Gerrity, "Harriet Jacobs," 70; italics in original. See also Gerrity, *Beyond Emancipation*, 108.

[52]According to *Incidents*, Joseph surmised that his mother was living in Molly's house but kept the secret. Jacobs reveals herself to him shortly before fleeing north (130), having previously disclosed herself to her daughter before the girl was sent to live with Sawyer's relatives in Brooklyn (117–18).

[53]Gerrity, *Beyond Emancipation*, 14. For Gerrity's fuller explanation of his theorisation of marronage, see ibid., 1–27.

Even before Gerrity's contributions, some definitions of marronage have been as broad and inclusive as the following one, which Steven Hahn—after acknowledging that marronage in the Americas did not always mean large settlements of fugitives in remote regions—uses as a starting point for his reflections:

> Considered as groups or collections of fugitives seeking some sort of existence outside enslavement, [maroon communities ...] were more likely to be small and to be found in relatively close proximity to towns and plantations, especially if the slave society lacked difficult terrain or was dominated chiefly by plantation agriculture.[54]

Hahn adds that such communities "were important sites of cultural and political development",[55] and he then applies this insight to Black communities in the pre-Civil War North, stating that such settlements "often came to *resemble* maroons not simply because they included substantial numbers of fugitives but also because of the ways in which they developed in relation to the larger world of slavery around them".[56] It worth noting that, rather than straightforwardly calling Black communities in the North "maroon communities", Hahn frequently employs "hedges" or "soft" turns of phrase, such as "[t]he maroon *analogy*",[57] or "*[l]ike* maroons, these enclaves of fugitives and freed blacks across the northern states [...]".[58] Also, Hahn discusses "maroons" *and* "fugitives", instead of seeking to categorically discredit such established terms as fugitivity, as Gerrity is more willing to do. But even so, Diouf (whose approach I privilege, in part because her southern focus is particularly relevant to my consideration of Jacobs's fugitivity in Edenton and its environs) reads Hahn's approach as obscuring the boundary between fugitivity and marronage in a way that she herself does not endorse.[59] Diouf is clear that, in *Slavery's Exiles*, her own usage of marronage is narrower than the "broad definition" that identifies marronage with any "act of fleeing enslavement" without any caveats or specifications.[60] Her book focuses on those maroons who "went to the Southern woods to *stay*",[61] and she explicitly excludes from her attention "runaways making their way through the wilds to reach a Southern city or a free state or to cross international borders".[62] Jacobs, whatever her original intentions, became the *latter* kind of runaway: she fled to the North when an opportunity eventually opened up.

Diouf further explains that the maroon collectives and individual maroons on whom she concentrates in *Slavery's Exiles* "shared three key characteristics: they settled in the wilderness, lived there in secret, and were not under any form of direct control by outsiders".[63] When elaborating on these conceptual criteria, Diouf, notably, expands her notion of wilderness to cover not only "hinterlands" but also "borderlands": "hinterland maroons" were maroon communities that were "secluded and hard to reach [...] because of the difficulty of the terrain", whereas "borderland maroons", according to her definition, "lived, individually and collectively, not far away but on the periphery of

[54]Hahn, *Political Worlds*, 27.
[55]Ibid., 28.
[56]Ibid., 30; italics added.
[57]Ibid., 43; italics added.
[58]Ibid., 32; italics added.
[59]Diouf, *Slavery's Exiles*, 2.
[60]Ibid.
[61]Ibid., 1; italics in original.
[62]Ibid.
[63]Ibid.

farms, plantations, and cities".[64] But even so, it is clear that Jacobs's confinement in the garret does not fulfil Diouf's criterion of "wilderness", not even in the sense of borderland marronage, because Jacobs's hiding place was not on the town's periphery but in *downtown* Edenton. Jacobs's depiction of her first Christmas in hiding highlights both this geographical centrality and Molly's cunning interactions with the town's white establishment: in this Christmas story, Jacobs stays in the garret, quiet as a mouse, while Molly invites two guests, including the town constable, to Christmas dinner and "take[s] them all over the house" to avoid suspicion and to demonstrate that she is a law-abiding Edentonian who has nothing to hide (102). Molly's carefully choreographed performance under the white constable's gaze is, of course, an act of resistance—here, of masked resistance. However, Diouf defines maroons as those runaways who left the white-ruled society behind *completely*, refusing to conform to it in any way, *and* who lived and moved autonomously in what she calls a "maroon landscape": "Borderlands and hinterlands formed the 'maroon landscape,' a vast area whose several parts were connected by secret paths, discreet trails, and waterways navigated under cover of night and whose outer, intangible limits reached, dangerously, into the plantations and cities".[65] In addition to autonomy and exile, Diouf, indeed, emphasises *mobility* as another crucial aspect of marronage, even in the borderlands:

> In the borderlands, men and women gathered the herbs, barks, and roots that formed the basis of their medicinal remedies. They collected black moss to fill mattresses [...]. Borderlands were spaces of freedom that provided what enslaved people were denied elsewhere: autonomy, mobility, enterprise, a sense of physical security, freedom from scrutiny, control over their time and movement.[66]

It is obvious, in light of the above, that Jacobs's confinement in the garret does not fall into the conceptual category of marronage as defined by Diouf. While other, broader definitions (including Gerrity's) exist, I, for one, wish to maintain a conceptual distinction between fugitivity and marronage—or treat marronage as a historically specific subcategory of fugitivity—in order to acknowledge the historical uniqueness of marronage.[67]

This said, there is no doubt that Jacobs, as Gerrity argues, was familiar with the phenomenon of runaways hiding in forests and swamps. In addition to narrating her own experience in Cabarrus Pocosin, she also mentions how, following Nat Turner's rebellion, "[m]any women hid themselves in woods and swamps" (58); her gendered word choice reveals Black women's fear of sexual violence during the vindictive raids, especially night-time ones (58), carried out by "the low whites, who had no negroes of their own to scourge" (57). Besides these short-term concealments, Jacobs also seems

[64]Ibid., 5.
[65]Ibid., 10.
[66]Ibid., 8.
[67]Having privileged "domestic fugitivity", I should add that the term *cimarronaje doméstico*, or "domestic marronage", also exists. The Dominican historian Celsa Albert Batista coined this term in the context of discussing enslaved women in colonial Hispaniola, especially on the island's eastern part that is now the Dominican Republic (*Mujer y esclavitud*, 45–7). However, Albert applies her concept to sociocultural settings and Black enslaved women's freedom-expanding endeavours that were very different from Jacobs's self-concealment in the garret. In Albert's metaphorical usage, "domestic marronage" refers to strategies by which enslaved women sought to expand their liberties when, for example, being hired out as day labourers; the term describes negotiation with the institution of slavery and cunning resistance to it, but not fugitivity in the eyes of the law. My Spanish is rudimentary, so I thank warmly my Providence College colleague Alison Caplan, who kindly helped me to translate and understand the relevant passages from Albert's book.

to have been aware of the existence of more permanent maroon communities in the area, as her rendering of a discussion on the ship that took her to Philadelphia and freedom suggests. When the vessel passes Cabarrus Pocosin, the captain says, "There is a slave territory that defies all the laws" (133). Recalling her short stay there, Jacobs thinks to herself: "[T]hough it was not called Dismal Swamp, it made me feel very dismal as I looked at it" (133). Given this repetition of "dismal", I concur with Gerrity that it is hardly a coincidence that Jacobs—who clearly knew what the name "Great Dismal Swamp" connoted for Black and white Southerners—uses the adjective "dismal" more than once in describing the garret, calling it a "dismal hole" (97, 124) and a dismal "cell" (104).[68] Gerrity also examines other, related lexical choices in *Incidents*, and he legitimately discerns, especially in Jacobs's usage of "hole" and "den", what he persuasively calls "a deliberate affinity with spaces of marronage and with the potentialities for alternative freedom, autonomy, and self-determination that these spaces create".[69]

Where does this leave us? I posit that Gabrielle Foreman's term "simultextuality" offers a constructive way of thinking of the simultaneous presence of both fugitivity and marronage in *Incidents*. The fact that Jacobs explicitly applies the term "fugitive" to herself does not exclude the possibility that *Incidents* also signals solidarity with Black maroons in the antebellum South. Foreman's *Activist Sentiments* is "invested in tracing the ways in which Black women's writing 'reads' multiple communities and ideologies".[70] Her analysis of *Incidents* underscores that Jacobs "offers her reception communities explicit directions to look for multiple modes of interpretation"—namely, "alternatives" that "are simultextual; that is, they are interpretive paths that offer equally substantive, often competing, simultaneously rendered modalities".[71] Applying this concept of "simultextuality" to the question of fugitivity and marronage (which is not Foreman's own focus in *Activist Sentiments*) helps to discern the following simultaneity and simultextuality in *Incidents*: On the one hand, Jacobs obviously, and for good reason, allied herself with the northern abolitionist project of opposing the Fugitive Slave Law and, in so doing, fulfilled abolitionist expectations. On the other hand, she was intimately familiar with the multiplicities, and the multiple precarities, of Black life in the South. For example, she knew that not every runaway had what she had in Edenton—a free Black family member who was willing to risk everything by offering her own house as a hiding place from which the domestic fugitive could eventually flee further; also, she knew that not every runaway was willing to leave the region that they thought of as home. Most importantly, Diouf remarks that "[f]or the maroons, the alternative to bondage was a clandestine life outside white-controlled space and *abolitionists had no use for them*, except to paint them as lost souls living among and like wild beasts, so as to underscore the cruelty of slavery".[72] While Jacobs wrote *Incidents* in the context of northern abolitionism, and of the discourse of fugitivity that resonated with her own life experience, she also subtly inscribed her awareness and memory of southern marronage in *Incidents*. She thereby signalled compassion for and existential kinship with the maroons and, importantly, avoided the classist binary that saw little, if any, existential similarity between marronage and what

[68]See Gerrity, *Beyond Emancipation*, 115; Gerrity, "Harriet Jacobs," 81.
[69]Gerrity, *Beyond Emancipation*, 115; Gerrity, "Harriet Jacobs," 81.
[70]Foreman, *Activist Sentiments*, 3.
[71]Ibid., 20.
[72]Diouf, *Slavery's Exiles*, 12; italics added.

northern abolitionists regarded as the more "civilised" varieties of long-term fugitivity. While Camilla Hawthorne and Jovan Scott Lewis identify "Jacobs's garret" as an example of those "putatively marginal subjects and spaces" that Black Geographies scholarship views as "sites from which the workings of power writ large can be analyzed and denaturalized",[73] Jacobs herself included southern maroons and the Great Dismal Swamp in such subjects and spaces as well.

Coda

This article has shown, first, that *Incidents* uses the language of geography and spatiality to highlight both slavery's terror and the strategic capabilities of the owned to negotiate with their owners. Second, I have demonstrated that Jacobs frames her years-long self-confinement in the garret as domestic fugitivity facilitated by a significant and sustained family effort. I have supported this reading by showing how systematically even the *pre*-garret chapters narrate the crucial importance of Molly's household to Jacobs's physical and psychological survival throughout her childhood, adolescence, and young womanhood. Third, given this article's rootedness in Black Geographies scholarship and its expansive approaches to spatiality, I have also engaged in a conceptual discussion of Jacobs's representations of fugitivity and marronage. I have suggested that applying Foreman's concept of "simultextuality" to this topical conversation opens up an interpretive space that helps *both* to honour the historical specificity of marronage *and* to recognise the subtle ways in which Jacobs expresses solidarity and existential kinship with southern maroons in her memoir.

Additionally, given the ever-important issue of gender as well as the recently reawakened scholarly interest in John Jacobs (following Jonathan Schroeder's rediscovery and 2024 re-publication of *The United States Governed by Six Hundred Thousands Despots: A True Story of Slavery* [1855], written by John Jacobs, and the simultaneous publication of Schroeder's pioneering John Jacobs biography, *No Longer Yours*),[74] it is worth restating that the notion of space is intimately tied to the dialectic of mobility and containment in the study of the narratives of both Harriet and John. Schroeder, who frames John's *Despots* as a "global slave narrative",[75] due to John's status as a world traveller,[76] engages in a mobility-focused comparison of the two Jacobs siblings' post-Edentonian lives:

> The only paying jobs available to John as a Black man required him to be hypermobile and prevented him from establishing a home in any normative sense. As a Black woman, Harriet found that her opportunities were precisely the opposite: *hypo*mobile, domestic jobs confining her to work in a white family's home.[77]

[73]Hawthorne and Lewis, "Introduction," 10.

[74]See John Jacobs, *Despots*; Schroeder, *No Longer Yours*. John Jacobs's much shorter memoir, *A True Tale of Slavery*, was initially published in the London periodical *The Leisure Hour: Family Journal of Instruction and Recreation* in instalments in February 1861. For Schroeder's discussion of the differences between *Despots* and *A True Tale of Slavery*, see *No Longer Yours*, 170.

[75]See Schroeder, "Introduction."

[76]*Despots* is no travelogue, but Schroeder's *No Longer Yours* reveals that after John Jacobs left the Northeast following the passage of the Fugitive Slave Law of 1850, he participated in two gold rushes on the Pacific rim, the Californian and Australian ones, and travelled all over the globe as a sailor. After his arrival in London in 1857, he "became a career mariner" who "[o]ver the next fifteen years […] worked more than thirty voyages as a steward or cook on ships transporting goods to and from England" (Schroeder, *No Longer Yours*, 164).

[77]Ibid., 183; italics in original.

Because John was constantly on the move after leaving Edenton, Schroeder's remark on Harriet's "hypomobility" makes sense in the context of *this* comparison, which specifically focuses on the intersection of race, gender, and labour, and on the related contrast between domesticity (which Schroeder sees as fixity) and movement. However, in an often-ignored 2007 essay entitled "Incidents Abroad: Harriet Jacobs and the Transatlantic Movement", Yellin compellingly highlights Jacobs's mental and intellectual mobility: she writes about Jacobs in her "earliest anonymous public writings [...] participating anonymously in the transatlantic debate over slavery, and then openly raising a public voice as an African-American woman engaged in the international movement of freedom".[78] Yellin's essay sheds light on Jacobs's evolving intellectual and political transnationalism, including how, "[o]n August 1, 1864, she dramatized her transatlantic worldview for the Union soldiers of Alexandria, Virginia, when, after weeks of careful planning, she presided over Alexandria's first commemoration of British West Indian Emancipation".[79] Equally importantly, Yellin's 2004 biography of Jacobs meticulously covers her post-Edentonian *physical* travels and relocations—not only Jacobs's two well-known trips to London but also her often-overlooked yet important work in Washington, DC, and Alexandria during the Civil War as well as her postbellum work in Savannah, Georgia.

Indeed, Jacobs lived in multiple locations, continually embracing new challenges and prioritising "black livingness" over social death both for herself and for the next Black generations. Danielle Purifoy has recently placed McKittrick's "black livingness" in dialogue with W. E. B. Du Bois, arguing for what she calls "a Du Boisian methodology in pursuing Black geographies—attention to the political, the economic, and the poetic in the service of rejecting social death as the primary means of characterizing Black life and place-making".[80] Black Geographies, as a field, is currently tracing its ancestors, and Du Bois is, no doubt, a worthy forefather. However, when it comes to a search for fore*mothers* of the kinds of spatial methodologies that Purifoy calls for, Jacobs—who certainly "reject[ed] social death as the primary means of characterizing Black life and place-making" both in her memoir and throughout her life—is an obvious choice.

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[78]Yellin, "Incidents Abroad," 158.
[79]Ibid., 168.
[80]Purifoy, "Call Us Alive Someplace," 30.

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